

Backup Strategies

Every user has to adjust her or his backup strategy according to their requirements. One of the primary decisions is the frequency of backup. For home users, where the amount of data generated is not too much, a manual backup—as and when required—will be enough; but in the case of a small firm consisting of about 10 to 20 employees, it won't work. In this case, a systematic schedule needs to be set to make sure that the data on each computer is backed up regularly. Moreover, the data backup schedule should not interfere with the regular working schedule of the users. The best option, therefore, is to schedule backups at night after office hours. The next important aspect is the size of the backup. Almost any backup software worth its name provides at least two levels of backup—full and modified. In Full backup, all the data from the specified location is backed up irrespective of whether the data is modified or is in its original form. This form of backup is the most inefficient and consumes lots of space. Modified backup is a much more sophisticated method that can let you back up only the modified parts of the data, thereby saving system resources.

test this feature right after a blackout in the test centre with a Word document. Although MSWord did recover most of the document, EasyRecovery managed to repair with only a minimal loss of formatting.

An interesting tool in EasyRecovery is its floppy-based self-booting diagnostic DataAdvisor tool. This is different from its emergency bootable diskette—as it does not perform any recovery functions. However, it is very good at identifying a disk's current health and predicting the problems it may encounter in the future. This makes it invaluable for system vendors and their customers alike, as the performance and life of a hard disk can be determined beforehand, which will lead to fewer replacements after sales, and better customer satisfaction.

During our tests, we noticed a number of helpful warnings that were generated, asking to save the recovered data on any media other than the affected hard disk. This level of alertness was missing from the other two tools. EasyRecovery also has a in-built file viewer which can be used to preview files like text files, Word documents etc. Although we found that this viewer has fairly limited capabilities, it can still be used to selectively recover specific files, particularly when you have a large partition and the list of files that can be recovered is large.

Purely in terms of performance, EasyRecovery was at best on par with the others, especially in the document recovery test with only 8 files completely recovered, both in terms of size and content. The scanning time too was quite high, only a few seconds faster than R-Studio.

However, despite all the mediocre test results that it displayed, EasyRecovery really stands out as the only recovery tool in our tests with nifty features that can be used by users unfamiliar with the recovery process and experts, alike.

- + Very simple and easy-to-use interface
- Slow scanning

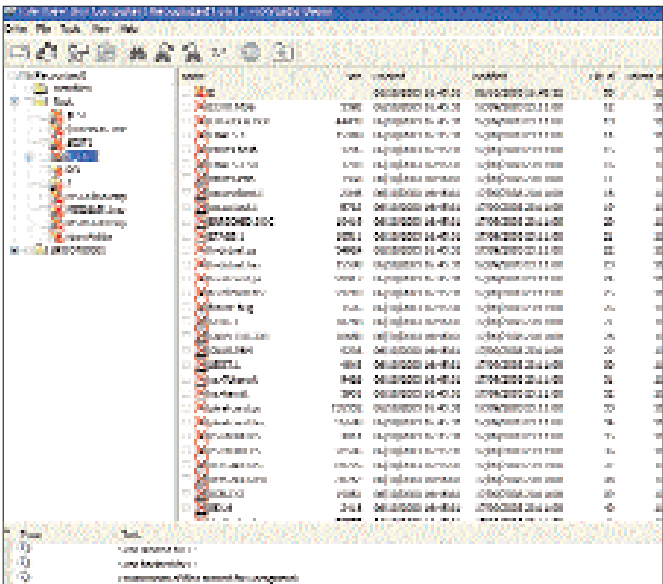
Auto Backup 2.2	
Performance	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Features	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Ease of use	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Overall	■ ■ ■ ■ ■

R-Studio FAT

Slow Joe

R-Studio FAT comes across as recovery software developed for system administrators, rather than for the average home user. This is well-reflected by the interface, which is very detailed and lists out the details of every storage device connected to the computer—even the floppy drive showed up, along with the free space and the internal geometry of the disk.

Surprisingly, in our tests, R-Studio was the only tool which supported remote recovery over a network, albeit only after installing its companion software, R-Studio Agent. R-Studio Agent can also be remotely installed over a network. R-Studio also supports the creation of disk images which are perfect, byte by byte copies of entire partitions. Though the software cannot schedule the regular creation of disk images, the images that we



R-Studios provides a very detailed interface that lets you select the files to be recovered

Data Destroyers

Data loss can occur due to a number of reasons. Some of the common ones are listed below:

- Virus attack:** Many viruses are notorious for deleting files. Some try to delete or overwrite the partition table, which stores the start and end locations of the data partitions on the disk.
- Accidental deletion of files:** This is a very simple reason for data loss: the user deletes some important files without moving them to the recycle bin first. The user may also delete files from the command prompt, or through applications that do not utilise the Recycle Bin, for example, WinRAR.
- Physical problems with the hard disk:** This is by far the most common reason for data loss, and also the most difficult to remedy. Hard disks can develop a multitude of problems, starting from faulty read and write head alignment, to a badly damaged head actually glued to the hard disk platters due to stiction (static friction).